

Client Onboarding Checklist

Run this checklist every time a client says “yes.” It turns a verbal agreement into a professional engagement — and sets the tone that you run a real operation.

Phase 1 — Lock It In (Day 0, the day they say yes)

- ☐ Send a same-day confirmation email (use Email Script #5, “Kickoff Confirmation”)
- ☐ Send the contract for signature (see Contract Essentials Checklist)
- ☐ Send the deposit invoice — **do not start work before the deposit clears**
- ☐ Create the project folder (files, assets, deliverables, admin)
- ☐ Add project milestones to your calendar, including a mid-project check-in

Phase 2 — Kickoff (within 3 business days of signed contract + deposit)

- ☐ Schedule a 30-minute kickoff call
- ☐ Send a kickoff agenda 24 hours before the call:
 - Goals recap (what success looks like, in the client’s words)
 - Deliverables and dates
 - What you need from them, and by when
 - Communication plan (channel, response time, meeting cadence)
- ☐ On the call, confirm the **single point of contact** who gives final approvals
- ☐ Confirm who provides assets (logins, brand files, copy, access) and the deadline for them
- ☐ State your revision policy out loud (e.g., “Two revision rounds are included; additional rounds are billed at my hourly rate”)

Phase 3 — Access & Assets (within 5 business days)

- ☐ Collect all logins/access via a secure method (password manager share link — never plain email)
- ☐ Collect brand assets, content, and reference materials
- ☐ Log the date each item was received — **if client delays cost you time, you’ll want the paper trail**
- ☐ Send a short “we’re fully set up” note once everything is in

Phase 4 — Working Rhythm (ongoing)

- ☐ Send the Weekly Status Update every Friday (Template #7)
- ☐ Log scope-change requests the moment they happen (use Email Script #6 to respond)

- ☐ Invoice on the schedule stated in the contract — never “when it feels polite”

The 3 Rules That Make Onboarding Work

1. **No deposit, no work.** A client who resists a 25–50% deposit is showing you how they’ll behave at final invoice time.
 2. **Everything in writing.** Decisions made on calls get confirmed by email within 24 hours (“Recapping what we agreed today...”).
 3. **One approver.** Projects die when three people give conflicting feedback. Name the approver in the kickoff call and the contract.
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